lander's touchdown on the lunar surface signifies a major step towards more challenging goals. ISRO's Aditya-L1 mission, its most complex ever, is scheduled to be launched in early September. Under it, the space module will monitor the Sun so as to provide early warnings about solar storms that can damage our satellites and electrical grids.

India's proposed Mars orbiter programme, its second, is well on track, and the ongoing Gaganyaan programme will demonstrate our human spaceflight capability by

INDIA'S MARS MISSION IS WELL ON TRACK. THE GAGANYAAN PROGRAMME WILL LAUNCH A CREWED SPACEFLIGHT ON LOW EARTH ORBIT

launching a three-member crew to an orbit of 400 km around the Earth and bring them safely back home. The recovery of astronauts from a mission is considered to be one of the main challenges of spacefaring. However, Gaganyaan is still years away. ISRO engineers and scientists have, with the help of a string of research institutions across the country, found ways to shorten the learning curve to enable India to embark on this next frontier of space exploration. Teams of scientists are working on evolving end-to-end capability in design, development, communication networking and the safe recovery of the spacecraft. An operable 'crew escape system', allowing for the extrication of astronauts in case of a contingency, is being assembled.

Chandrayaan-3's success confirms that India is now a leading space power. What follows in its exploratory arc will establish beyond doubt that India is vital to global space research. ■



INFLATION

FOOD FOR THOUGHT

By M.G. Arun

Amid the rising food prices squeezing household budgets, retail inflation soared to 7.4 per cent in July, breaching the Reserve Bank of India (RBI)'s upper tolerance limit of 6 per cent. This was the highest inflation figure—measured in terms of the Consumer Price Index (CPI)—in the past 15 months, and significantly above the 4.8 per cent recorded in June. The previous high—at 7.8 per cent—was registered back in April 2022.

The latest inflation data not only belies the RBI's hopes of cutting the interest rates anytime soon. Instead, it raises the spectre of the central bank increasing the interest rates should inflation hover above the 7 per cent mark for another month.

Either way, it is not good news for those with existing retail loans or who had been awaiting lower interest rates for home and consumer loans to make their purchases. High inflation can hurt consumption, as prices of goods rise. This, in turn, hurts private investment, which has been slowing for quite